(Afzal has admitted his guilt in court). This is blatantly untrue. Then, for a full fifteen minutes the ‘confession’ ran without comment. After this, an anchor came on and said, ‘Sansad par hamle ki kahani, Afzal ki zubaani’ (The story of the Parliament attack, in Afzal’s words.) This, too, is a travesty of the truth. Well into the programme a reporter informed us that Afzal had since withdrawn this ‘confession’ and had claimed it had been extracted under torture. The smirking anchor then turned to one of the panellists, S.A.R. Geelani, who was also one of the accused in the case (and who knows a thing or two about torture and the Special Cell), and remarked that if this confession was ‘forced’, then Afzal was a very good actor.

(The anchor has clearly never experienced torture. Or even read the wonderful Uruguayan writer Eduardo Galeano—‘The electric cattle prod turns anyone into a prolific storyteller.’ Nor has he known what it’s like to be held in police custody in Delhi while his family was hostage—as Afzal’s was—in the war zone that is Kashmir.)

Later on, the ‘confession’ was juxtaposed with what the channel said was Afzal’s statement to the court, but was actually the text of a letter he wrote to his high court lawyer in which he implicates the State Task Force (STF) in Kashmir and describes how in the months before the Parliament attack he was illegally detained and tortured by the STF. NDTV does not tell us that a Deputy Superintendent of the STF has since confirmed that he did illegally detain and torture Afzal (see Appendix III). Instead it uses Afzal’s letter to discredit him further. The bold caption at the bottom of the frame read: ‘Afzal ka badalta hua baiyan’ (Afzal’s changing statements).

There is another serious ethical issue. In Afzal’s confession to the Special Cell in December 2001 (as opposed to his ‘media confession’), he implicated S.A.R. Geelani and said he was the mastermind of the conspiracy. While this was in line with the Special Cell’s charge sheet, it turned out to be false, and Geelani was acquitted by the Supreme Court. Why was this portion of Afzal’s confession left out? So that the confession would seem less constructed, more plausible? Who made that decision to leave it out? NDTV or the Special Cell?

All this makes the broadcast of this programme a seriously prejudicial act. It wasn’t surprising to watch the ‘collective conscience’ of society forming its opinion as the show unfolded. The SMS messages on the ticker tape said:

Afzal ko boti boti mein kaat ke kutton ko khila do. (Cut him into bits and feed him to the dogs.)